

Chapter 1. On Shelves and Their Discontents

What a rendering engine must preserve, then, is not merely the glyphs but their spatial relation: the gutter, the measure, the position of a footnote relative to the sentence that summoned it. Rasterising the page and treating it as an image is crude, but it is honest about what it is preserving, and it fails in visible rather than invisible ways.

Distance is the enemy of legibility. Text that is perfectly crisp at three hundred dots per inch on paper becomes a grey smear at twelve pixels of screen height per line, and no amount of texture resolution will recover it, because the limit is the display, not the source. The only real lever is to bring the page closer or make it larger.

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 1

HAIRLINE RULES 1.0 / 0.5 / 0.25 pt



PAGE 1

Chapter 2. On Shelves and Their Discontents

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 2

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

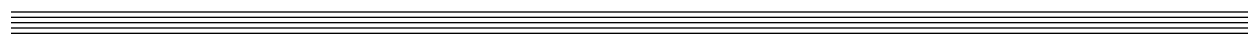
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 3

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PAGE 3

Chapter 4. On Shelves and Their Discontents

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 4

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PAGE 4

Chapter 5. On Shelves and Their Discontents

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 5

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 6

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6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

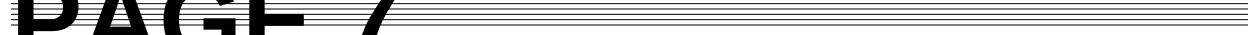
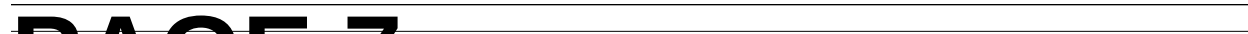
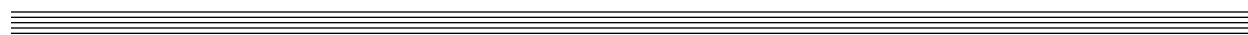
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 7

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 8

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PAGE 8

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6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

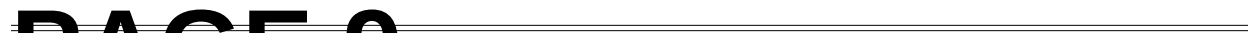
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 9

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

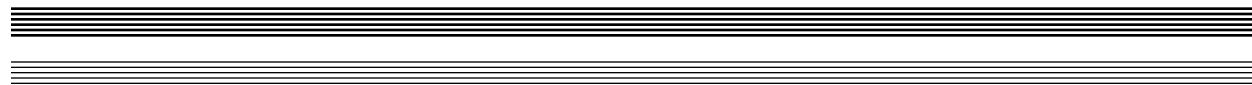
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 10

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Chapter 11. On Shelves and Their Discontents

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

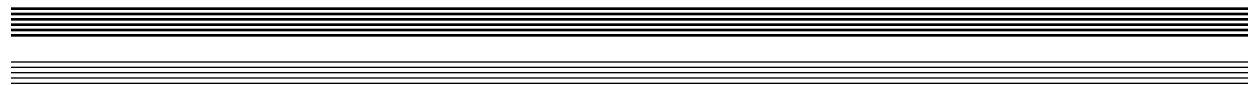
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 11

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PAGE 11

Chapter 12. On Shelves and Their Discontents

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

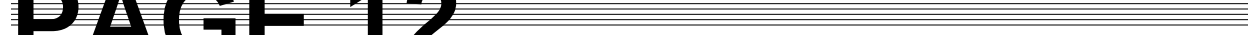
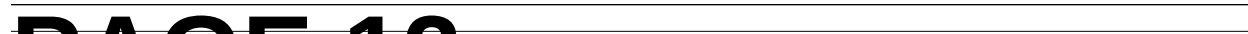
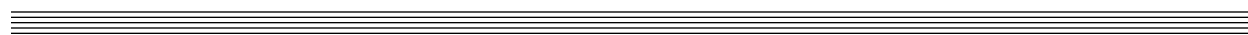
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 12

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6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 13

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 13

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 13

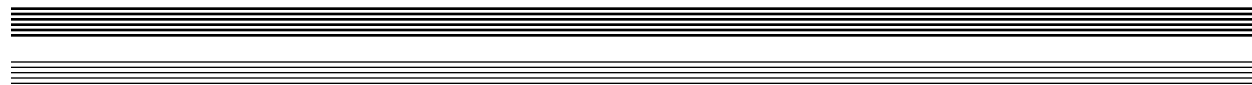
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 13

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 13

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 13

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

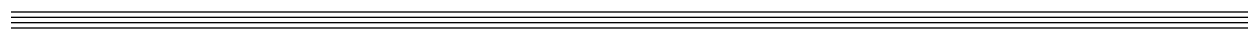
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 14

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PAGE 14

Chapter 15. On Shelves and Their Discontents

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LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

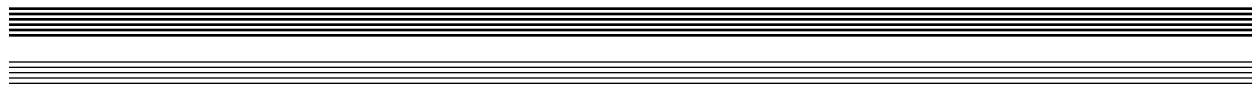
9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 15

HAIRLINE RULES 1.0 / 0.5 / 0.25 pt



Chapter 16. On Shelves and Their Discontents

A library is not a warehouse of finished thoughts but an instrument for producing new ones. The shelf is the argument: what stands beside what, which spine catches the eye on the way to somewhere else, which book has been pulled so often that it no longer sits flush with its neighbours. Cataloguing systems try to freeze this into an order, and every reader quietly subverts it.

Consider the physical act of reading. The hand knows roughly how far in a passage sits before the eye confirms it. The thickness under the left thumb is a progress bar that no digital reader has convincingly replaced, and the slight resistance of a page turning is feedback that the text has moved on without you having to look for a page number.

The typography of a page is a set of promises about how long you will be here. Wide margins say the publisher expects marginalia. Tight leading says the text is dense and you should slow down. A running head says you will lose your place and will need help finding it again. None of this survives a naive translation into a scrolling column of reflowed HTML.

What a rendering engine must preserve, then, is not merely the glyphs but their spatial relation: the gutter, the measure, the position of a footnote relative to the sentence that summoned it. Rasterising the page and treating it as an image is crude, but it is honest about what it is preserving, and it fails in visible rather than invisible ways.

LEGIBILITY LADDER

6pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

7pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

8pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

9pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

10pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

11pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

12pt The quick brown fox jumps over the lazy dog 0123456789 -- page 16

HAIRLINE RULES 1.0 / 0.5 / 0.25 pt

